



SHRIYA PATIL, SHINDE

AFTER THE CRACKDOWN

DEADLINES The music goes off and the bar takes the last order at 11 p.m. All-night partying is passé.

IDENTITY PROOF If you want a midnight stroll, carry a valid identity card as police patrols routinely check identity.

IDENTITY CARDS AT HOTELS Each time you check into a hotel, you will be asked for an identity card.

OVERSTAYING WILL NOT BE ALLOWED Living with a local family and setting up shops beyond the visa validity period is a no-no for foreigners.

by a 5,000-strong mob and the Government ordered an inquiry against the police officer. It is widely believed that the accused was close to MLA Babush Monserrate. "The ministers are only concerned about saving their chair and do not care about policemen suffering in the bargain. Each time an MLA threatens to withdraw support, the government gives in to his demands," says an IPS officer.

Apart from shaky governments, the small size of the state and its constituencies plays a major role in poor administration. Almost every family knows someone connected to the local minister or MLA. "You have to think ten times before suspending someone because once you punish a person and then revoke the order, it causes great embarrassment," says an MLA. A small constituency with less than 18,000 voters ensures that local strongmen often call the shots during elections.

With Goa coming into the global spotlight for all the wrong reasons, the Government is desperately trying to sell the state as a safe tourist spot and attract the well-heeled corporate traveller as opposed to the charter flights bringing plumbers and electricians. During Fiona MacKeown's campaign against corrupt cops and politicians (she accused Home Minister Ravi Naik and Director-General of Police B.S. Brar of being involved with the drug mafia), Chief Minister Digambar Kamath

"IN THREE YEARS, THE ASSEMBLY HASN'T WORKED PROPERLY FOR EVEN 20 DAYS."

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MANOHAR PARRIKAR,
FORMER CHIEF MINISTER

rushed to Delhi for a meeting with Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, who advised him to clean up Goa's act. The new crackdown came into force immediately, aimed at targeting the more upmarket tourist. Private agencies have been invited to maintain beaches along with state authorities. Convention centres and amusement parks are planned to attract business travellers and their families.

Residents, however, are not so sure if the new initiatives will sustain beyond the lean summer months of tourist inflow. Most fear that the hippie culture, what author William Dalrymple calls "fossilised relics of Haight-Ashbury", and the attendant problems of drugs, alcohol and general low life are too deeply ingrained in Goa's popular culture to be eliminated. The Russians and Israelis have barricaded themselves behind their secluded enclaves but that is no hindrance to the mafia-style activities they indulge in. The nexus between crooked cop and crooked politician that is impossible to break, more so now when the builders with big bucks to spend have joined the party. Goa's existential dilemma will not be easy to resolve. The choice is a hard one: to allow the tourist Euros to flow and maintain the image of a 24x7 party place or crack down on the illegal activities and permanently stoned hippies and clean up the beaches. Till then, Goa will continue to live on the edge. ■